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# THE REINVENTION WORKBOOK



*A guided writing workbook for people in the middle of becoming  
someone new.*

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BY MK PARRISH · \$18

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\$29

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## HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

You are not lost. You are between drafts.

That restless, ungrounded feeling, like you have outgrown a life that still has your name on it, is not a breakdown. It is a manuscript in revision. Something is being rewritten, and the discomfort is just the gap between the old version and the one that has not fully arrived yet.

This workbook is for that gap. It will not hand you a five-step plan or a personality quiz that flattens you into a color. Reinvention is not a system. It is a writing practice. You become someone new the same way you write anything true: draft, cut, revise, keep the line that surprised you.

Thirty exercises follow, in five parts. Do them in order or out of it. Use a real notebook if you can; there is something about a hand moving across paper that bypasses the editor in your head. Each prompt has instructions, a few questions, and, where it helps, an example response so you know the depth I am asking for. The examples are mine or composites. Do not copy them. Let them set the floor, then go past it.

“

*You do not find yourself. You write yourself. One honest sentence at a time.*

Set aside the urge to do this perfectly. The mess is the point. Begin.

### *A few ground rules before you start*

**Lower the bar to enter, raise the bar to leave.** Do not wait for the perfect ninety-minute window with candles lit. Five honest minutes on a page beats an hour you keep postponing. Start ugly. You can always go deeper once you are already moving, but you cannot deepen a page you never opened.

**Tell the truth on paper before you tell it to anyone.** This notebook is the one place you do not have to manage how it lands. No one is grading it. No one is reading over your shoulder. The whole method depends on you being more honest here than you are anywhere else, so protect that. If you would not write it because someone might find it, write it somewhere they will not.

**Expect resistance, and read it as a signal.** The exercises you most want to skip are usually the ones with your name on them. When you feel the urge to flip past a prompt, put a small mark next to it and come back. Resistance is not a stop sign. It is an arrow pointing at the thing.

**Reinvention is not erasure.** You are not deleting yourself and starting over. You are recovering the parts of you that got edited out to keep other people comfortable, and building them more room. Keep that in mind every time the work starts to feel like self-rejection. It is the opposite. It is a homecoming.

## PART ONE: THE IDENTITY AUDIT

Before you build the new, take inventory of the old. You cannot revise a draft you have never read closely.

Most people try to change without ever auditing what they are changing from. They lunge at a new job, a new city, a new look, and bring the same unexamined self along for the ride, and six months later wonder why the new life feels like the old one wearing a different coat. The audit is how you avoid that. You are going to read your current self the way an editor reads a manuscript: with care, without cruelty, and with a pen.

### *Exercise 1 — The Inventory*

**Instructions:** List ten roles, labels, or identities you currently carry. Job titles, relationships, the descriptions you reach for at parties. Next to each, write one word: *keep*, *cut*, or *unsure*.

#### *Example:*

- Marketing manager, unsure
- Reliable one, cut
- Daughter, keep
- The funny friend, keep
- "Not creative," cut

The *cut* and *unsure* lines are your real material. Circle them.

## *Exercise 2 — On Loan vs. Owned*

**Instructions:** Take three labels from Exercise 1. For each, write a sentence answering: did I choose this, or was it handed to me? Be honest about the inherited ones.

**Example:** "Reliable one' was handed to me at about age nine, when being the easy kid kept the house calm. I have been paying interest on it ever since."

## *Exercise 3 — The Costume Test*

**Instructions:** Describe a version of yourself you perform that does not match how you feel inside. Write it in third person, like a character. What does she wear, say, withhold? Then write one sentence on what it costs you to keep her up.

## *Exercise 4 — The Energy Map*

**Instructions:** Make two columns. Left: everything in your week that drains you. Right: everything that returns you to yourself. Do not moralize the lists; some draining things stay, some energizing things are impractical. Just look. Where is your life out of balance with who you actually are?

## *Exercise 5 — The Eulogy You'd Hate*

**Instructions:** Write the two-sentence summary of your life that would be true if nothing changed from today. The version that makes your stomach drop a little. This is not despair, it is a compass. The drop tells you which direction is wrong.

**Example:** "She kept everyone comfortable and herself postponed. She was, by every external measure, fine."

## *Exercise 6 — The Quiet Yes*

**Instructions:** Reinvention is not only about what is wrong. Write about the last time you felt fully, quietly like yourself, no performance, no managing anyone, just at home in your own life. Where were you? What were you doing? Who, if anyone, was there? That memory is not nostalgia. It is data about the direction of the new draft.

## PART TWO: EXCAVATING THE OLD STORY

You have been narrating yourself for years. Some of that narration is true. Some of it was installed by people who needed you to stay a certain shape.

Here is the strange thing about the stories we tell about ourselves: we mistake them for observations when they are actually instructions. "I am not good with money" is not a neutral fact you discovered. It is a script you have been following, and the following is what keeps making it true. This part is about finding the scripts, reading the fine print, and deciding which ones you are done performing.

### *Exercise 7 — The Story You Tell About Yourself*

**Instructions:** Write your origin story the way you usually tell it, the "this is who I am and how I got here" version. One paragraph. Then read it back and underline every sentence that sounds like a limitation stated as a fact. ("I have never been good with money." "I am just not a leader.")

### *Exercise 8 — Find the Author*

**Instructions:** Take three underlined limitations from Exercise 7. For each, write whose voice it is. A parent? A teacher? An ex? An era of your life? You will often find the belief is not yours; you have just been carrying it so long it feels native.

**Example:** "I'm not creative" is my third-grade teacher's voice, who graded coloring inside the lines. I have been believing a woman who is no longer alive about a skill she never tested."



## *Exercise 9 — The Greatest Hits of Being Misread*

**Instructions:** List three times someone got you completely wrong, underestimated you, mislabeled you, decided who you were before you spoke. For each, write the truer version. Notice how often the misreading became something you half-believed.

## *Exercise 10 — What You Quit Believing*

**Instructions:** Write about something you used to be certain of that you no longer are. A belief, an ambition, a person, a version of the future. Do not mourn it or celebrate it. Just describe the shift. Reinvention is partly the art of letting a belief die without dying with it.

## *Exercise 11 — The Debt You Did Not Sign For*

**Instructions:** Identify one expectation you have been working to repay that you never actually agreed to. The career someone assumed you would want. The role in the family. The version of success that belongs to a person who is not you. Write what it has cost you to keep paying it, and then write the sentence that cancels the debt.

## *Exercise 12 — The Permission Slip*

**Instructions:** Write a permission slip to yourself, signed, for the thing you keep waiting for someone else to authorize. Make it specific. "I give myself permission to \_\_\_\_." Then answer: who did you think had to sign this instead of you?

“

*Most of us are waiting for a permission that was never going to come from the outside. You are the only signature that was ever required.*

## PART THREE: VOICE & NARRATIVE

You cannot become someone new in a voice that belongs to your old self. This part is about how you sound, to yourself, on the page, out loud.

Voice matters more in reinvention than people expect, because the way you talk to yourself is the way you build yourself. If your inner narration is still written in the cramped, apologetic, second-guessing language of the self you are leaving, you will keep rebuilding that self no matter what you do on the outside. Change the language and you start to change the person speaking it.

### *Exercise 13 — Your Unedited Voice*

**Instructions:** Set a timer for five minutes. Write about your day with zero editing, no fixing, no making it sound smart. Read it back and highlight the three phrases that sound most like *you* and least like a LinkedIn post. That is your raw voice. We are going to keep it.

### *Exercise 14 — The Words That Aren't Yours*

**Instructions:** List words and phrases you use because they sound professional, safe, or expected, but that you secretly hate. ("Circle back." "I'm passionate about." "Just wanted to check in.") Cross them out. Write what you would say instead if you trusted yourself.

### *Exercise 15 — Describe Yourself Without the Résumé*

**Instructions:** Introduce yourself in three sentences without mentioning your job, your accomplishments, or anyone you are related to. Who are you when the credentials are off the table? Harder than it looks. That

difficulty is the assignment.

### *Exercise 16 — The Letter From the Future You*

**Instructions:** Write a letter to yourself from the version of you two years into the reinvention, the one who already made it through this gap. What does she want you to stop apologizing for? What does she find funny now that you find terrifying? Let her be kind and a little impatient.

**Example:** "Dear you, stop drafting the email seventeen times. She presses send. That is the whole difference between us. Also: you were right about the thing you talked yourself out of. Go back to it."

### *Exercise 17 — Your One Sentence*

**Instructions:** Reinvention needs a thesis. Write the single sentence that captures who you are becoming. Not a job title. A stance. Revise it ten times. The tenth one is usually the real one.

**Example, drafts 1 and 10:**

1. "I want to be a writer who helps people."
2. "I help people rewrite the story they were handed into one they would actually sign."

### *Exercise 18 — The Anti-Mission Statement*

**Instructions:** Write down everything you are *not* doing anymore. The relationships, the apologies, the shrinking, the roles. Naming what you are leaving behind is as defining as naming what you are walking toward. "I am not the one who manages everyone's feelings at the expense of my own. Anymore."

## PART FOUR: BUILDING THE NEW DRAFT

You have audited the old and found your voice. Now you write forward.

This is where most reinvention books get vague and inspirational, and where this one gets concrete. Becoming someone new is not a lightning strike. It is a sequence of small, deliberate, slightly uncomfortable actions, repeated until the new self stops feeling like a costume and starts feeling like skin. The exercises here are about motion, the unglamorous logistics of change done with conviction.

### *Exercise 19 — The Reinvention Inventory, Revisited*

**Instructions:** Return to your *cut* and *unsure* list from Exercise 1. For each one you are ready to cut, write the small first action that begins the cut. Not the dramatic gesture, the quiet first move. Reinvention is mostly unglamorous logistics done with conviction.

### *Exercise 20 — One Brave Sentence a Day*

**Instructions:** For the next seven days, write one true sentence each morning that the old you would not have written. Track them here. By day seven, read them in order. You will see a person changing in real time.

**Example sequence:** "I am allowed to want more." / "I told her no and survived it." / "My work is good even when no one claps." / "I am not behind. I am rerouting."

## *Exercise 21 — The Identity Rehearsal*

**Instructions:** Pick one trait of the person you are becoming. Spend one full day acting as if it is already settled fact, then write what happened. Did the sky fall? It rarely does. We rehearse the new self into existence before we believe in it. Belief is the last thing to arrive, not the first.

## *Exercise 22 — The Smallest Possible Experiment*

**Instructions:** Pick the reinvention you are most afraid is "not realistic." Design the smallest possible test of it that you could run this week, with no permission and almost no risk. One coffee, one paragraph published, one hour of the new work, one honest conversation. Write the experiment, then schedule it. Reinvention is a hypothesis you test, not a leap you have to take blind.

## *Exercise 23 — Who Goes With You*

**Instructions:** Make two lists. The people who make you feel more like the person you are becoming, and the people who reliably pull you back toward the old draft. You do not have to cut anyone. You do have to be honest about who gets a vote in your life right now, and to spend your scarce energy accordingly.

## *Exercise 24 — The Obstacle, Reframed*

**Instructions:** Name the biggest practical obstacle between you and the reinvention. Money, time, a dependent, a fear, a skills gap. Write it plainly. Then, underneath, write the same obstacle as a problem to be solved in steps rather than a wall that ends the conversation. Most "impossible" is just "unsequenced."

## PART FIVE: LIVING THE NEW DRAFT

A draft is not finished when you write it. It is finished when you live inside it long enough that it stops feeling like fiction. This final part is about making the new self durable, so it survives the ordinary Tuesday, the setback, the old crowd, the inevitable day the doubt comes back.

### *Exercise 25 — The Closing Manifesto*

**Instructions:** Using everything in this workbook, your one sentence, your anti-mission, your true lines, your future self's letter, write a one-page manifesto for who you are now. Present tense. No hedging. Read it out loud. Then read it again when you forget. This is the new draft. It is allowed to keep changing. So are you.

### *Exercise 26 — Your Evidence File*

**Instructions:** Start a running list of evidence that the new self is real: moments you acted from it, things you said yes or no to, the small wins no one else noticed. On the hard days, the old story will tell you nothing has changed. The evidence file is how you argue back with facts.

### *Exercise 27 — The Relapse Plan*

**Instructions:** You will, some week, slide back into the old self. Plan for it now, while you are clear. Write down the three earliest warning signs that you are shrinking again, and the one small action that reliably brings you back to the new draft. A relapse is not a failure of reinvention. It is part of it. The plan is what makes it temporary.

## *Exercise 28 — The Quarterly Re-Read*

**Instructions:** Put a date three months from now on your calendar, titled "Re-read the manifesto." On that day, read your closing manifesto, then write a short note to yourself about what is now true that was only aspiration when you wrote it. Reinvention is not a one-time event. It is a practice with a review cycle.

## *Exercise 29 — Teach One Person*

**Instructions:** Find one person at the start of their own gap, the place you were when you opened this book, and tell them one true thing you learned here. Nothing makes a new identity solid like becoming the person who can hand it to someone else. You do not have to have arrived. You only have to be one honest chapter ahead.

## *Exercise 30 — The Next Honest Sentence*

**Instructions:** Close the workbook by writing the single next sentence you most need to write, the one this whole process has been circling. Do not explain it. Do not soften it. Just write it, and let it be the first line of whatever comes next.

“*You were never broken. You were a first draft. And the best thing about a draft is that it was always meant to be revised.*”

# KEEP GOING

Reinvention is not a weekend. It is a practice, and practices need company.

If the excavation in Parts One and Two opened something tender, especially if the old story was written by someone who hurt you, read **The Invisible Bruise**, which sits with that wound directly.

If you are ready to take your new voice public, into your bio, your brand, the rooms you want to be in, **Write Yourself Into the Room** is the next step.

Find more at **mkparrish.com**, where I write about voice, identity, and the long, worthwhile work of becoming.

You picked up the pen. That was always the hardest part.

— MK Parrish



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